A beginners guide to *least* painful rogaining

(Composed by Grant Hunter with the Heights of Winter in mind, updated 2002)

Planning

- A good mix of planning and navigation skills, and fitness, is the rogainer's secret. Planning your course thoughtfully and understanding the map are at least as important as fitness.

- Plan your day well before the physical stuff starts. Estimate how far you think you can travel (don't expect to visit all check points). Pick a circuit you think is within reach, remembering you must be back by the finish time, and that some travel may be in darkness. Perhaps 12 hours is too long for the first time? There is no need to be out for the full duration.

- As a guideline, top teams fairly consistently cover about 45 km, measured as straight-line distance between checkpoints on the map, over 12 hours. One grid square on the map is 1 km on the ground. Add more for the ups and downs and the wiggles. Don't get too optimistic and end up having to walk or run back from the middle of nowhere to keep within the deadline.

- To help your planning, colour in the check points according to their point values. Stick pins into the map over cardboard and trace cotton around them to measure distance. Draw circles out from the start point to show distances involved. How far? How much climbing? (Climbing means crossing the brown contour lines, upwards.)

- Think about how to link checkpoints to minimise the distance you travel, including climbing and descending, while maximising points. Be prepared to adjust your course as the day progresses, depending on progress.

- Check last minute instructions and map corrections on the whiteboard at the start.

Using the Map

- The map is your main navigation aid. You might use a compass to keep the map oriented (lined up so that features on the map are in the same direction as they are on the ground). You are unlikely to need a compass for fine navigation to find checkpoints, except in fog and darkness.

- Get to know what the map symbols mean and visualise what they look like on the ground. Brown contour lines (close together means steep ground), fences, streams, forest patches, saddles, rock outcrops, etc. are important.

- To ORIENTATE the map, either:
    - visually line up features (e.g. streams, fences, forest patches, ridges) on the map with the corresponding features on the ground. Usually this is adequate in feature-laden terrain and with good topographical maps, or
    - lay the compass on the map with its north-south engraved markings parallel to the map north-south grid lines. Rotate the map and the compass together until the compass needle is parallel with the **magnetic north** pointer on the map margin or the overprinted magnetic grid lines running top right-bottom left (**not the published 'up and down' grid lines of the map**).

- Topographical maps with relief shading can trick us when read upside-down. You may see ridges as valley floors and vice versa. To avoid this, keep the map with the northern edge uppermost and the writing up the right way. This means you cannot always keep it orientated and you will need to rotate the image in your mind as you flip-flop from map to the ground.

- The map is a snapshot in time. The shape of the land won't change much, but don't be perplexed when you discover a track that is not marked on the map, or you find extra fences, or fences have gone, etc. Vegetation can change too.

On the move

- Take it easy at the start. It takes time to build the judgement to relate the map to the ground, and to get your eye in for relating map distance to ground distance. Be especially careful to find the first checkpoint. It'll build your confidence and eye for country. Don't uncritically follow the team in front. If they drop you, you'll lose whatever sense-of-landscape you had developed.

- When departing one checkpoint for the next, first determine the general direction in which to travel, using the orientated map. Then pick your route – it may be along an obvious feature such as a spur, stream or fence. A track if you're lucky. If there is no obvious route, identify some middle-distant feature in the direction of the checkpoint, both on the map and on the ground. Monitor your progress towards the target. Keep tabs on each recognisable feature (e.g. streams, fences, spurs) that you pass on the map (orienteers call it "thumbing the map"). Once you lose track of individual features it is hard to sort out where you are.

- Use linear "collecting" features such as fences, streams or ridges to navigate and follow – they allow you to monitor progress and to keep on a particular line. Pace counting may help you judge the distance travelled.

- It often helps to deliberately aim to one side of your target. Then you can be sure that the checkpoint lies out to one particular side, rather than not knowing whether to look to the left or the right as you approach it.

- Rogaining check points are not hidden in the landscape, and are usually visible from at least 20m away. They should be located very close to the centre of the circle. Descriptions are straightforward. "The …" on a checkpoint description sheet means that the particular feature (e.g. "The tree") is depicted on the printed map. "A tree" means the specific tree is not marked on the map, but it will be clearly visible in the field.

- If you can't immediately locate the checkpoint, check and double-check your position, even if it means some backtracking. Once found, it will give you greater confidence to proceed, and a known location from which to navigate onwards.

- Occasionally, checkpoint flags get removed or blown away between course setting and the event. If this happens, sign the intentions sheet (if present) and describe on your card some distinctive feature near where you think the checkpoint should be. Do the latter if you're convinced the checkpoint is in the wrong place. (It happens).

- Ensure you reach the finish by close-off time. If not you'll incur severe points penalty. It's a safety matter as well.

Always

- Heed all safety instructions and landowner-courtesy advice in mail-outs and briefings, and use your common sense. Your safety and the future of rogaining might depend on it. Rogaining enjoys excellent landowner and rural community support.

- Enjoy your day, and remember it's as much about enjoyment, and learning about navigation and the landscape, as about competition.